Threads of Severance: The Final Thread

A Tabletop Roleplaying Game of Bonds, Truth, and Breaking

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Part One: Welcome to the Threaded World

In this world, love isn't private. It's written directly into the fabric of reality itself. WHen two people Bind their souls at a Temple, a spiritual tether forms between them, recognized by government, neighbors, and the land. When that bond begins to fracture, when emotional truth is denied or suppressed, the world doesn't stay quiet about it. Cold spots form in hallways. Glowing crops dim. Phantom doubles appear in empty rooms.

Threads of Severance is a tabletop roleplaying game for 2-5 players, built around the central question "What happens when the truth you're avoiding starts reshaping reality around you?". Players take on the roles of Temple Resonants, Vale Harmonists, or Shardbound, each with their own relationship to bonds, rituals, and emotional truth, navigating a continent on the edge of cosmic fracture.

What You Need to Play

ITEM	DESCRIPTION
2-5 Players	One Game Master and one to four players taking on character roles.
Dice	A pool of 6 d6s.
Character Sheets	Provided at the back of the document. One per player.
Bond Tokens	Use coins, stones, or any small objects, 5 per player to start.
Thread Cards	Index cards for tracking active Bonds between characters and NPCs.

Part Two: The Resonance System - Core Rules

The Resonance System reflects the world's central truth: actions have emotional costs, and the state of your soul directly shapes what you can do. Every roll is about more than success or failure. It's about what the attempt reveals.

Core Statistics

Each character is defined by four core statistics, ranging from 1 to 5. These are chosen during character creation and can grow, but only through confronting emotional truth in play.

STATISTIC	WHAT IT GOVERNS
RESONANCE	Your capacity to sense, attune to, and influence soul bonds. Governs Binding, Severing, and detecting instability in others.
PROJECTION	Your skill at separating your soul from your body and navigating the astral plane. Governs exploration, dream entry, and astral encounters.
GROUNDING	Your ability to stay tethered to your body, resist soul drag, and anchor others during projection. It's a critical defensive stat.
TRUTH	Your willingness to confront emotional reality, both your own and others'. Most rituals require a truth check. It's the hardest stat to raise and the most important.

Secondary Tracks

Soul Stability (SS) Rated 0-10. Starts at 6 + Grounding. This is your spiritual health. Taking emotional damage, failing rituals, or prolonged projection all reduce SS. At 0, your character enters Soul Crisis, which is a state where they cannot project, cannot perform rituals, and must make a truth check at the start of each scene or suffer an involuntary manifestation.
Bond Strain (BS) Rated 0-10. Tracks the health of an active Bond between your character and an NPC or another player character. Starts at 0. Every ignored incompatibility, dishonest Severing attempt, or suppressed manifestation raises BS by 1. At BS 10, the Bond enters fracture, generating hauntings and threatening those nearby.
Echo Debt (ED) Rated 0-5. A long term track. Every failed Severing ritual adds 1 ED. At ED 3, your character attracts minor Echo Wraiths. At ED 5, a full Resonance Demon begins to form around you.

Echo Debt can only be cleared by a fully honest, mutual resolution.

Making Rolls

When a character attempts something risky, the GM calls for a roll. Assemble a dice pool of d6s equal to the relevant statistic (1-5 dice). Roll all of them and count successes: any die showing 4, 5, or 6.

RESULT	OUTCOME	EFFECT
3+ Successes	FULL SUCCESS	Achieve your goal cleanly. No cost.
1-2 Successes	PARTIAL SUCCESS	You succeed, but something costs you. The GM introduces a complication, or you pay an emotional toll(reduce SS by 1).
0 Successes	FAILURE	You fail, and the world reacts. The GM triggers a manifestation, increases Bond Strain, or escalates instability.

Spending/Earning Bond Tokens

Bond Tokens represent the emotional reserves your character has built through honest connection. You begin each session with 5 tokens. Spend them as follows:

Add a die to any roll	Spend 1 token before rolling to add one extra d6
Resist a Manifestation	Spend 2 tokens to refuse one incoming haunting or Echo intrusion.
Aid Another	Spend 1 token to grant a nearby ally 1 extra die on their next roll.
Speak True	Spend 1 token to automatically succeed on a Truth check, but you must actually roleplay the honest confrontation out loud.

You gain Bond Tokens when you roleplay a genuine moment of emotional honesty, successfully resolve a Bond's tension, or help another character confront something they've been avoiding. The GM awards these in the moment and they cannot be farmed or planned.

Part Three: The Unique Verbs - Actions in Play

The world of Threads of Severance is defined by five unique actions. Each verb has specific mechanical rules that reflect both what the world makes possible and what it costs to attempt.

Project

You partially or fully separate your soul from your body, entering the astral plane. While projected, you can observe emotional wounds as physical distortions, enter shared dreamscapes, and perceive the threads connecting bonded individuals.

How to do it: Roll your projection stat.

RESULT	EFFECT
Full Success (3+)	You enter the astral plane cleanly. You may move freely, observe soul threads, and interact with astral entities for the scene.
Partial (1–2)	You project successfully, but your body suffers. Reduce SS by 1. Your physical form is vulnerable while you are gone.
Failure (0)	Your soul snaps back violently. Reduce SS by 2. The GM triggers an involuntary manifestation.

For every scene spent projected beyond the first, make a Grounding roll or lose 1 SS. Prolonged separation causes fever, memory gaps, and temporary sensory loss.

Bind

Two characters undergo a temple ritual to magically entwine their souls. This formalizes a Bond, unlocking cooperative abilities and shared perception, but also creating shared vulnerability.

How to do it: Requires the willing participation of both parties. The officiating character rolls Resonance.

RESULT	EFFECT
Full Success (3+)	The Binding is clean. Both characters gain 1 Bond Token immediately and may share perception once per session: spend a Bond Token to see through the other’s senses for a single moment.
Partial (1–2)	The Binding forms but is fragile. Bond Strain starts at 2 instead of 0. Something is already slightly wrong.

Failure (0)	The ritual reveals immediate incompatibility. No Bond forms. Both parties make a truth check or suffer 1 SS loss from the rejection.

A Binding cannot be faked, as it amplifies what already exists emotionally. A character already Bound to another cannot Bind again without soul fragmentation(immediate Soul Crisis).

Manifest

Emotional repression becomes physically real. A character channels suppressed emotion into paranormal phenomena, or, more dangerously, it happens to them involuntarily when their truth track is neglected.

How to do it: Voluntary Manifestation rolls use truth. Involuntary manifestations occur on failed truth checks imposed by the GM.

RESULT	EFFECT
Grief	Creeping fog. Phantom doubles of the absent. Ambient whispers that repeat unspoken words.
Anger	Poltergeist activity. Shattered objects. Temperature spikes. Items thrown across rooms.
Longing	Phantom duplicates of the desired. Involuntary soul projection in nearby witnesses.
Denial	Reality distortion. Echoes forming. Bond Strain +1 on all nearby active Bonds.

Every Manifestation roll, successful or not, increases your personal Bond Strain by 1. Offensive soul magic risks destabilizing your own Bond. Combat in this world is inherently self-sacrificing

Sever

A Severing ritual attempts to dissolve a soul Bond. This is the game's centerpiece action, emotionally demanding, narratively rich, and mechanically layered. It cannot be rushed. It cannot be faked.

How to do it: A Severing is an extended scene, not a single roll. See Part Six for the full ritual. At minimum it requires a projection roll to enter shared astral space, a truth roll from each bonded party, and a final resonance roll.

RESULT	EFFECT
Clean Severing	Both parties speak truth. No Echo forms. Bond Strain drops to 0. The district stabilizes.

Partial Severing	Separation completes but a minor Echo forms. Bond Strain remains at 3 as a lingering haunting.
Collapsed Severing	Both parties take 2 SS damage. Echo Debt +2. The Bond enters Fracture.

Both participants lose 1 SS regardless of outcome. Being publicly Severed carries social stigma, reputation in institutional settings decreases until rebuilt. One partner refusing to acknowledge the fracture causes severe backlash: automatic failure and Echo Debt +2 for the refusing party

Reconcile

Instead of breaking a Bond, two characters confront their incompatibility and attempt to reshape it into alignment. Reconciliation is rarer and harder than Severing since it requires both parties to be simultaneously vulnerable and honest.

How to do it: Both characters must each succeed on a truth roll in the same scene.

RESULT	EFFECT
Both succeed	Bond Strain decreases by 3. A genuine moment of mutual acknowledgement occurs.
One succeeds, one fails	Bond Strain decreases by 1. The failing party loses 1 SS.
Both fail	Bond Strain increases by 1. An involuntary Manifestation occurs immediately.

Reconciliation cannot be one sided. No amount of resonance skill or Bond Tokens can substitute for genuine mutual acknowledgement. If only one partner attempts it, the effort automatically fails.

Part Four: Character Types

Your character type isn't a class in the traditional sense. It's a worldview, a set of abilities earned through a particular relationship with soul bonds, and a set of starting beliefs that the game will challenge. Each type begins with a unique ability, a signature weakness, and a different relationship to the five core verbs.

Temple Resonant

Formally trained regulators of soul bonding and Severing. They operate from Lumenreach and believe incompatibility is spiritually dangerous and must be managed through ritual honesty.

Starting Stats	Resonance 4, Projection 3, Grounding 3, Truth 2
Starting SS	8
Starting Bond Tokens	4
Signature Ability	RITUAL PRECISION: When conducting an official Binding or Severing ritual, the Resonant may reroll one die that shows a failure. They must keep the second result.
Signature Weakness	DOCTRINE OVER TRUTH: When Truth is below 3, the Resonant cannot initiate a Reconcile action. Their instinct is to manage, not to acknowledge. They must spend 2 Bond Tokens to override this.
Verb Bonuses	Project: +1 die in stable regions. Sever: May conduct the ritual solo for NPCs.

Vale Harmonist

Agrarian bond keepers from the Verdant Vale who treat bonding as communal rather than bureaucratic. Their crops physically respond to resonance stability, making emotional honesty a matter of survival and communal pressure a real danger.

Starting Stats	Resonance 3, Projection 2, Grounding 4, Truth 4
Starting SS	7
Starting Bond Tokens	6
Signature Ability	GROUP ATTUNEMENT:

	Once per session, the Harmonist may roll resonance to sense the emotional state of everyone in the immediate area, including suppressed feelings. On a full success, they know exactly who is withholding truth and roughly what it concerns.
Signature Weakness	COMMUNAL PRESSURE: When the Harmonist witnesses open conflict between allies, they must spend 1 Bond Token or immediately attempt to deescalate, even if the conflict is necessary. They physically cannot stay out of it.
Verb Bonuses	Reconcile: +2 dice. Manifest: -1 die.

Shardbound

Descendants of those displaced by the 351 AB forced Severing. Labeled “tainted” by the Temple. They navigate unstable projection zones and carry oral histories that directly contradict the official record.

Starting Stats	Resonance 2, Projection 4, Grounding 3, Truth 4
Starting SS	6
Starting Bond Tokens	5
Signature Ability	FRACTURE SIGHT: The Shardbound perceives astral spaces others cannot, hidden Echo clusters, dead zones expanding before they’re visible, and the residue of forced Severings. They automatically succeed on checks to detect instability or locate Echoes.
Signature Weakness	GENERATIONAL ANGER: When the Shardbound witnesses an institution suppress emotional truth, they must make a truth check or immediately and publicly confront the suppression, regardless of tactical cost.
Verb Bonuses	Project: May enter projection dead zones without SS loss. Sever: +1 die when the Severing involves a victim of forced separation.

Part Five: Maslow’s Hierarchy of Needs in Play

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Tier 1: Physiological Needs

Food and Water	Resonance instability spoils supplies. The GM may call for a Grounding roll in any region with active Bond Strain 6+. Failure means the group’s food stores are tainted, tasting metallic, inducing vivid dreams, or simply rotting overnight. Wells near areas of failed Severings may cause involuntary projection in those who drink from them.
Transport	Bound partners cannot separate beyond a day’s travel without soul drag penalties. Traveling pairs must make grounding rolls every 48 in game hours of separation or suffer -1 die to all actions from the accumulated drag.
Reproduction	Soul conception requires a cooperative Projection into a shared dreamscape. This is an extended ritual scene with both physical and emotional stakes, and it cannot begin if either partner’s Bond Strain exceeds 4.

Tier 2: Safety Needs

Shelter	Homes built without spiritual protections are vulnerable to poltergeist escalation. Characters sleeping in unprotected buildings during active hauntings must make a grounding roll or suffer 1 SS loss from disrupted projection during sleep.
Offense	Soul magic can be weaponized, but at cost. Each offensive Manifestation increases personal Bond Strain by 1. Combat through manifestation is self sacrificing by design.
Defense	Protective magic focuses on grounding, not blocking. A successful grounding roll can

	disperse a hostile manifestation, but the defender must articulate what they are grounded in. Purely mechanical defense does not work.

Tier 3: Belonging Needs

Religion and Community	The Temple's authority is social infrastructure. Characters who are publicly Severed lose access to Temple waystations, official bond records, and certain legal protections. Vale communities and Shardbound clans offer alternatives, each with their own obligations.
Family	Failed Severings that produce Echoes can haunt future family structures. Children conceived during high Bond Strain show early signs of involuntary projection. This is a long term consequence campaigns can incorporate over multiple sessions.
Government	In regions with strict Temple oversight, unregistered relationships lack legal protection. Shardbound partnerships have no institutional recourse when threatened. This shapes which spaces characters can navigate safely.

Tier 4: Esteem Needs

Social Class	Each clean, mutual Severing a character oversees adds to their reputation track. Each failed Severing or Echo they generate subtracts from it. Reputation affects NPC willingness to cooperate and opens or closes narrative doors in institutional settings.
Economics	The entire economy surrounds bond maintenance. Characters can earn coin through ritual services, dream interpretation, stabilization charms, and Severing ceremonies. Prices rise during high instability periods. Shardbound offer unofficial alternatives at different rates and different risks.

Tier 5: Self Actualization

Mastery	True mastery is the campaign's long term reward. A character who raises their truth stat to 5 can perform a clean Sever, which is a Severing that produces no Echo Debt and requires only one truth roll instead of two. This is not about power. It is about emotional honesty becoming instinct.
Stat Growth	Statistics increase only through specific narrative triggers. Resonance grows when you stabilize a Bond in crisis. Projection grows when you return from an unstable astral space you had no right surviving. Grounding grows when you choose to stay present in a scene that would be easier to project out of. Truth, the hardest to raise, grows only when you initiate an honest confrontation you have been actively avoiding.

Part Six: The Severing Ritual - Extended Scene

The Severing Ritual is the game's centerpiece scene. It is emotionally and mechanically demanding by design. Running it well is the core skill of a Threads of Severance GM.

STEP 1: ENTER THE SHARED SPACE The officiating character (or one of the bonded pair) makes a projection roll to open a shared astral space. On full success, both bonded parties enter cleanly. On partial, one enters without warning and the memory sequence begins immediately. On failure, the astral space destabilizes and both parties make a grounding roll or lose 1 SS.
STEP 2: THE MEMORY SEQUENCE The GM narrates 3 defining memories from the Bond, two tender, one moment of suppressed incompatibility. Players must engage with these in character. After each memory, any character present may ask: "What did you feel here that you didn't say?" The bonded party must answer honestly or roll truth (2 successes required) to speak it.
STEP 3: THE TRUTH DECARATIONS Each bonded party makes a truth roll. On full success, they articulate their incompatibility clearly and without blame. On partial, they manage it but a fragment remains. The officiating character may spend 2 Bond Tokens to smooth it. On failure, the party resists getting Echo Debt +1 and Bond Strain +2.
STEP 4: THE SEPARATION If both truth rolls succeed (or are smoothed), the officiating character makes a final Resonance roll. Full success: clean separation, no Echo, Bond Strain drops to 0. Partial: separation completes but a minor Echo forms. Failure: the Severing collapses and both parties take 2 SS damage, Echo Debt +2, the Bond enters Fracture.
STEP 5: THE AFTERMATH Both parties lose 1 SS regardless of outcome. If the ritual was public, the GM applies social reputation consequences. If the ritual was clean, all nearby Bonds reduce their Strain by 1 from the resonance released into the environment.

If a Severing produces an Echo, don't treat it as a loss state. An Echo is a new narrative thread. It haunts the people involved, repeating the emotional fragments that were never spoken. The only way to dissolve it is the truth that was withheld, spoken aloud, in a scene, in character, without a roll.

Part Seven: The Game Master's Toolkit

The Instability Scale

The GM tracks a regional Instability Rating (IR) from 0 to 10. It starts at whatever level the scenario establishes and rises or falls based on player action.

IR	WORLD CONDITION
0-2	Stable. Crops glow. Dreams are private. Bonds register normally.
3-4	Minor phenomena. Cold spots. Animals unsettled. Involuntary projection is more common at night.
5-6	Active hauntings. Echo Wraiths form from failed Severings in the area. All Bond Strain increases by 1 per week of inaction.
7-8	Shared dreamstates across neighborhoods. Soul drag extends to separated friends, not just Bound partners. Resonance Demons begin forming.
9-10	Catastrophic. Soul threads visible to everyone. Mass involuntary projection. Crops fail. Reality distorts near areas of suppressed Bond Strain.

Enemies

Enemy	Description	Mechanical Cost to Players
Echo Wraith	Formed from failed or dishonest Severings. Does not attack physically, instead forcing a truth check on every character in the scene each round. On a failed truth check, the character is dragged into a memory loop and loses their action. Dispelled only when the specific suppressed truth that formed it is spoken aloud in play.	Bond Strain +1 SS -1 on failed truth check each round.

Resonance Demon	Large scale manifestation of accumulated emotional suppression. Warps the environment, amplifies emotional states, and generates Echo Wraiths as support. Cannot be defeated through combat alone, as it requires reducing the regional IR to below 5 first, then a successful Severing or Reconcile action directed at its source instability.	SS -2 to all nearby per round IR +1 for each round it's ignored
Dream Drifter	Exists between identity and memory. Mimics voices and appearances. Characters must succeed on a truth check each round to distinguish the Drifter from the person it's impersonating. Loses cohesion when a character asserts their identity clearly out loud, stating their name, type, and one thing they know is true about themselves.	Identity confusion status ailment May trap players in dream loops on failed grounding checks

Part Eight: Sample Scenario - The Fraying District

A scenario for 2-4 players. Suitable for a single session of 3-4 hours or the opening arc of a longer campaign. Starting Instability Rating: 5.

The Situation

A couple, Arven and Lysa, once considered a model Binding, has requested an official Severing. Their relationship has been fracturing quietly for years. Cold spots appear nightly in their district. Neighboring families report phantom doubles of Arven and Lysa wandering through walls. Crops in nearby Vale shipments are souring. The players have been dispatched to oversee, stabilize, or at least contain the situation.

The Complication

When the players enter the astral space for a preliminary projection, they discover that Arven and Lysa's soul threads are unusually tangled, not just with each other, but with something distant and enormous. The couple does not know this. The Temple records show nothing unusual. A Shardbound figure has been watching the cathedral from across the street for three days.

Key NPCs

Arven - Disciplined, emotionally withdrawn. He wants this to be over cleanly. He is suppressing grief. Bond Strain: 7.

Lysa - Desperate for acknowledgement. She knows something the Temple doesn't. She encountered an Echo in their home that repeated something she said to Arven three years ago that he refuses to acknowledge. Bond Strain: 9.

The Shardbound Watcher - Will not enter the cathedral. Speaks to players who approach outside. Knows the threads are connected to the Expanse. Doesn't trust the players yet.

Possible Outcomes

Clean Severing: Both parties speak truth. Threads stabilize. IR drops by 2. The distant entanglement dims but does not disappear.

Forced Severing: Players push through without emotional resolution. Technically completes. Echo forms immediately. IR rises by 1. The distant threads pull harder.

Collapse: Lysa or Arven refuses the Truth roll. Severing fails catastrophically. An Echo Wraith manifests in the cathedral. IR rises by 2. The Shardbound watcher leaves, but slides a note under the door.

The Note:
“What you saw in there? That’s not new. That’s old. Older than the Temple. Older than anything we know! They called what they did in 351 a precaution. We called it what it was... Find the Restricted Archives if you want to know what’s actually happening here.”